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UK Visa Status: Student Visa. Eligible for Graduate Visa (2 Years Full Working Rights)

16 October 2026

Hiring Team
Checkout.com

Application: Senior Machine Learning Engineer (Disputes ML)

Dear Checkout.com hiring team,

I am applying for the Machine Learning Engineer role in your Disputes ML team. I have spent three years at HDFC Asset Management taking machine learning and GenAI systems from prototype to production for the people who used them every day, and owning that lifecycle end to end - the pipelines, the deployment and the production troubleshooting - is the work I want to keep doing, applied to payments and disputes at Checkout.com's scale.

At HDFC I designed and built the applications end to end: a ReactJS frontend, Python FastAPI microservices and retrieval logic with LlamaIndex and Azure OpenAI GPT-3.5 and Llama-3, with a separate pgvector database per department and role-based access through the company LDAP server. The agents call Python functions as tools to run SQL-backed fund comparisons on our PostgreSQL data and produce PDF reports on request. I packaged the services as Docker containers and deployed them on AWS through a one-click Jenkins and GitLab CI/CD pipeline with dev and prod environments, and I took the applications through the security team's VAPT after they had repeatedly failed it.

The batch side of my work is a Python data pipeline that parses over 300 daily emails from credit rating agencies into structured data, fuzzy-matches them to the companies analysts track and sends a daily summary, saving 60 manual analyst hours a month. It runs on AWS SageMaker, triggered by an EventBridge rule and a Lambda function at 9 AM, and when one agency began sending its emails as images I moved parsing from Textract to Azure OpenAI. I also designed the Normalized SQL Schema behind our analytics platform and wrote the Python ingestion scripts for the Morningstar API covering every fund in the Indian mutual fund market.

I want to be direct about where my experience differs from your list. I have not trained or operated models on Databricks, I have not built a feature store, and I have not worked with Spark, Kubeflow, Seldon or Triton. My production work has been GenAI and automation systems rather than models served at high throughput, and my formal evaluation, drift monitoring and observability are limited: at HDFC quality came from user feedback, system-prompt guardrails and Compliance review rather than gold datasets or LLM-as-judge. My deep learning and ranking work is academic, and I have about three years of experience rather than five, though that time was spent shipping systems end to end. Those are the areas I would expect to grow fastest in on a team that runs ML at this scale.

For my MSc dissertation with AstraZeneca I co-built CellLineSelector, where I designed the scoring and ranking algorithm that ranks cancer cell lines by target inclusion and exclusion genes, the data preprocessing pipeline and the RAG layer, and we refined the ranking with feedback from AstraZeneca scientists. At HDFC I worked directly with Client Service, Compliance and Investment to turn requirements into working tools, and in my final year I acted as de facto team lead for up to four interns. Python is my day-to-day language and I am comfortable across the full lifecycle, from data pipeline to deployment to troubleshooting.

I am currently based in Bristol and am happy to discuss the hybrid arrangement and the three days a week in the office. I hold a Student Visa and am eligible for the Graduate Visa, which gives two years of full working rights. Thank you for considering my application; I would be glad to talk it through.

Yours sincerely,
Kaustubh Sonawane